



STILL AT ODDS
(L-R) An anti-OBC quota rally in Delhi in 1990; the Lohar community protesting in Patna to seek reservation, Apr. 2023

GETTY IMAGES

IF MANDAL 1.0 SAW THE DECIMATION OF THE CONGRESS AND THE RISE OF PARTIES LIKE THE SP, BSP AND RJD, THE OPPOSITION HOPES MANDAL 2.0 WILL DO THE SAME FOR THE BJP

Pradesh and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) in Bihar, the Opposition hopes that Mandal 2.0 will do the same to the BJP now. That, however, is easier said than done. The saffron party has, over the years, chipped at the base of the regional caste-based formations by wooing the OBCs, celebrating their icons, history and culture, and making them aware of the several government welfare schemes that they benefit from. Little wonder the OBC vote has been crucial in the two successive victories of the BJP in the 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha election. A 2019 study by the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS) in Delhi estimated that the OBC vote for the BJP doubled from 22 per cent in 2009 to 44 per cent in 2019.

It is this support that the Opposition aims to strike at by invoking Mandal 2.0. And the Bihar survey, it hopes, will be the foundation stone for this second phase of Mandal politics, helping it counter the BJP's politics of Kamandal (the sacred Hindu water pot as a metaphor), as part of which it seeks to subsume caste identity under a broader Hindutva narrative and highlight universal welfarism to pre-empt the fragmentation of the OBC vote along caste lines.

For the BJP, a caste census can have serious implications in a dozen-plus states that have massive OBC populations—UP, Bihar, Jharkhand, Rajasthan, Haryana, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. Together, they account for 374 of the 543 seats in the Lok Sabha. Four of them—Rajasthan, MP, Chhattisgarh and Telangana—will go to the polls later in the year, and will be the first test of the Mandal vs Kamandal battle.

The BJP itself has been fighting shy of stirring the hornets' nest. Though Rajnath Singh as the Union home minister in 2018 had promised that data on OBCs would be collected in the 2021 census, the Covid-19 pandemic put paid to the exercise itself and the Union ministry of social justice and empowerment, in an affidavit filed before the Supreme Court in 2021, said that a caste census was logistically unfeasible. The same year, Nityanand Rai, the minister of state for home affairs, told the Lok Sabha that the Union government had, as a matter of policy, decided not to enumerate caste-wise populations other than SCs and STs in the census.

THE OPPOSITION GAME PLAN

If calling their alliance INDIA was one master stroke, Mandal 2.0 will be equally heavy artillery in the hands of the Opposition, going into the Lok Sabha polls next year. By rooting for a caste-based census, the Opposition parties hope to consolidate the OBC vote by fostering a new consciousness regarding their numerical strength and using it to claim a higher share in the job and education quota. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi had indicated as much at an election rally in Kolar city in Karnataka on April 16, when he recast the Kanshi Ram slogan "*Jiski jitni sankhya bhaari, utni uski bhaagidari*" to declare "*Jitni aabaadi, utna haq* (Rights proportionate to the share of population)". And now, when